

Steve Butterworth

Full-Stack Rails Engineer

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PROFILE

Full-stack Ruby on Rails engineer with 20+ years of whole-product ownership, building, shipping and running software end to end, from customer conversation to production and long-term operation. That work spans everything from live systems serving over a million visits a day to a business-critical platform in production for 13 years and counting. Contracting since 2013, usually one long engagement at a time, and always joining to stay rather than pass through.

Deep Rails, with LLM pipeline work spanning classification, summarisation and a tool-calling chatbot. Comfortable owning everything from architecture to customer support. Quick to prototype and test ideas, and careful to keep production systems simple enough to stay reliable and easy to maintain.

Agentic engineering has become central to how I work. I drive coding agents under strict SDLC guardrails, applying judgement built over two decades of shipping code to production, and deliver cleaner, more reliable software far faster than I could a year ago.

SKILLS

- **Backend:** Ruby on Rails, API design, Sidekiq, RSpec.
- **Frontend:** Stimulus, Turbo, React, Tailwind, D3.js, Three.js.
- **Data:** PostgreSQL, Elasticsearch, Redis.
- **Operational tools:** Dashboards, admin workflows, reporting, alerting, monitoring, customer-facing reliability.
- **AI/ML support:** LLM classification, summarisation, data cleanup, prompt/workflow integration.
- **AI-assisted development:** Claude Code and Codex, driven by a suite of strict SDLC skills covering task breakdown, test-first development, coding standards, and security and performance audits.
- **Engineering practices:** Automated testing, CI, coding standards, security scanning, documentation, stakeholder communication.

EXPERIENCE

Full-Stack Rails Engineer, Environmentjob.co.uk (Contract)

2013 - Present

The UK's leading environmental jobs platform

- Build and maintain systems for job search, advertiser and job-seeker tools, admin workflow, CRM and reporting. Changes ship in days and stay in production for years.
- Designed the data model and built Elasticsearch full-text search, faceted filtering and an email alert system sending over 150k emails/week.
- Built AI import, clean-up and classification systems.
- Built a software tool for monitoring relevant new job postings across hundreds of websites.
- Full maintenance and upgrade journey from Rails 1 to Rails 8.

Founder & Rails Engineer, ChangeFlow

2023 - 2026

Bootstrapped AI-powered website monitoring and alerting SaaS, used by Am Law 200 firms

- Founded, built and operate a production Rails SaaS for website monitoring, change detection and customer alerting.
- Designed the core data model, monitoring pipeline, background jobs and notification workflows end to end.
- Integrated Puppeteer/Node.js browser automation with Rails, PostgreSQL, Redis and Factory/Sidekiq.
- Built LLM pipelines for classification, summarisation and cleaning, plus an in-app AI agent.
- Owned the full lifecycle, from deployment through production reliability to customer support.
- Now a stable, lightly maintained side product rather than an active venture.

Full-Stack Rails Engineer, NTT Data (Contract)

2014 - 2023

Engaged via LEX & Pulse Group

- Delivered time-critical live data-ingestion and visualisation systems for NTT DATA sports sponsorships including The Open, BMW International Open and Indy 500.
- Built Rails/JS/D3.js/Three.js systems powering live 3D shot tracking, public websites and large-format event displays.
- For ShotView, one of our marquee apps, liaised with various stakeholders and went from creative concept to over 1 million daily visits in 4 months.
- Turned creative briefs into working proofs of concept in days to secure sign-off and budget; tight event deadlines demanded simple, pragmatic solutions.
- Led a small team of software engineers and worked in a wider multidisciplinary team including creative directors and designers.

Full-Stack Rails Engineer, GSK MVOC Analyser (Contract)

2019

Engaged by AI firm Retechnica

- Built a medical voice-of-customer dashboard with analysis, reporting, interactive visualisation and PDF/PPT export.
- Shipped on time and on budget with a 9/10 satisfaction score from 50+ stakeholders.

Founder & Rails Engineer, Flumes

2010 - 2013

Social media analytics and visualisation platform, founded and built 0 to 1

- Built a social media analytics platform from scratch, covering live social data ingestion, enrichment and interactive visualisation.
- Enriched social data with sentiment, gender, age and geolocation classification by integrating third-party APIs.
- The platform became the technology foundation for later live-event and data-visualisation work, delivered for the likes of Cambridge University Press, Team GB and NTT Data.

Full-Stack Rails Engineer, AlphaSights

2008 - 2010

Information-services & advisory firm, Cambridge/London

- Joined as first employee, set the technology direction with the founders, and recruited and led the initial Ruby on Rails engineering team; the company has since grown to over 2k employees.
- Architected and built a bespoke CRM and customer-portal system underpinning the firm's client communications.
- Role covered product management, technical recruitment, coding standards, best practices, leadership, and system architecture.

ADDITIONAL

- **Co-Founder, Unicorn Studios Ipswich** (2019 - Present): a not-for-profit creative co-working space for remote workers, freelancers and contractors.
- **Rails & PHP Developer, Humble Technologies** (2006 - 2008): PHP and Ruby consultancy for UK clients, including lowcarbon.com and Chameleon Studios.
- **Senior Software Engineer, i2, Inc. (now part of IBM)** (2002 - 2005): led the web version of the flagship analytics tool; built a Java/JS SDK letting third parties embed its charting technology.
- **Software Developer, Crystal Decisions (now part of SAP)** (1999 - 2001): built enterprise OLAP components and a front-end JavaScript SDK, and mentored new developers.

EDUCATION

BSc (Hons) Computer Science, 1st Class, Manchester University